

Arches, orders and inscriptions

Using free-standing columns as stabilizers, the Romans developed the rounded stone arch. Arches are often used to support large expanses of wall, and for building foundations. They are built upwards from either side using a temporary wooden frame, and the final stone to be dropped into the centre of a span is the keystone. From arches, the Romans also developed arcades (a series of arches on columns) and the barrel vault, cross vault and dome. They used five orders on their columns. To the Greek Doric, Ionic and Corinthian (see [here](#)), they added the Tuscan (an even simpler form of Doric) and the Composite, a richer form of Corinthian.

Columns and passageways were decorated with reliefs and free-standing sculptures. Some triumphal arches were surmounted by a statue or a *currus triumphalis*, a group of statues of the emperor or general. Inscriptions had finely cut letters, carefully designed for maximum clarity and simplicity, with no decorative flourishes, emphasizing a Roman taste for restraint.

NARIUM · SEXTENS ·
DIVI · IVLI · QVIRIN
TATIS · MATRIS · M
M · BASILICAM · IV
M · REFECI · CAP
VM · RIVOS · VIAM ·
RV · ATQVE · ATH
PIDIS · IN · PROVI
SOVE · OVORVM · C